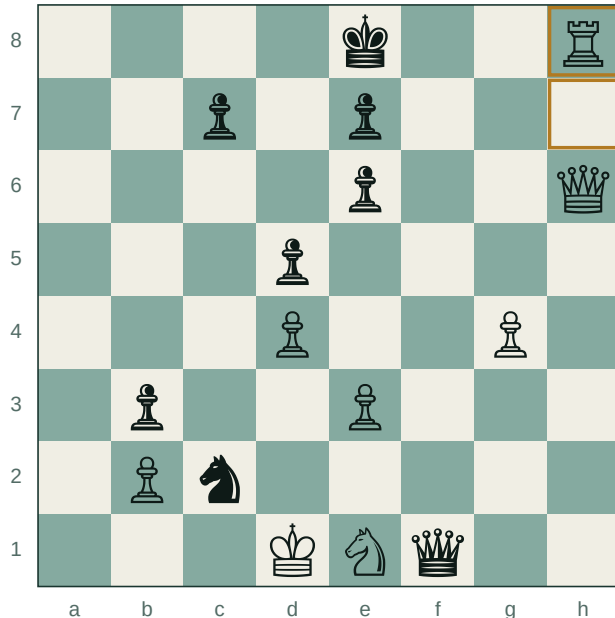


Active defensive resources: Black, move 34

Active defensive resources

Black to move



Previous move: 34.Rh8+. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

34...Kd7 35. Qh4 Nxe3+ 36. Kd2 Nc4+

34...Kd7 The king moves from e8 to d7. Recorded reply: **35.Qh4**.

35...Nxe3+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the pawn on e3. Recorded reply: **36.Kd2**.

36...Nc4+ Check restricts White to 3 legal replies here.

At the end, nominal material is White 20 / Black 17 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +1**: the balance goes from -4 to -3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A defensive puzzle may aim to preserve equality rather than win. Judge success against the threat, not only the final material count.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

The best defense may create a threat, exchange an attacker, or change the geometry of the attack. Identify the opponent's concrete idea before selecting a response.

HOW TO LOOK

Name the threatened move and the conditions it requires. Look for a move that breaks one of those conditions with tempo.

The defending king is on d1. Absolute pin: knight on e1.